



COVER STORY | LEADERSHIP FOR THE 21ST CENTURY

"We can't wait any longer"

YASIN MALIK CHAIRMAN, JKLF

Earlier this month, I was concerned when I heard PPP Co-Chairman Asif Ali Zardari propose that the issue of resolving the Kashmir dispute could wait and should be left for future generations to deal with. I was further distressed to see this notion welcomed in the media and within the public discourse in India. When two prime ministers say this, I see it as a recipe for disaster. What has this "passing of the baton" ever meant? For 60 years, three generations of Kashmiris have suffered this conflict and the injustice that it represents. My own generation finally lost faith in the effectiveness of a non-violent struggle and felt compelled to pick up the gun in 1988.

It is heart-breaking that Kashmiri Muslim and Kashmiri Pandit youth have grown up without each other's friendship. Today's youth in Kashmir possess an even deeper sense of anger and an even more intense sense of injustice than my generation felt

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D I S C U S S I O N

Q. Has increased women empowerment changed the way the women vote?

Kanimozhi: When political power shifts to women, policies are made keeping them in mind. Women can change things the way they want to. Today, the husbands no longer decide whom to vote for and neither would the women obey such commandments. They have both demands and expectations, which is why political parties are now considering women empowerment and bringing them in the mainstream. There has been a big shift.

Q. Don't you think reservation should be provided on economic lines rather than on the basis of caste and creed?

Pilot: Reservation is a provision in the Constitution of India and there is a set parameter

according to which it can be given. I am all for reservation of people who truly deserve it and I don't think I deserve a reservation. Why should a poor Brahmin or a poor Rajput who doesn't have food to eat not get the government's help? This is like an ovarian lottery. I am in favour of reservations on the basis of economic criteria.

Q. The poor are basically depended on altruistic quality of people who are well off. Is there something we can give to the poor people so that they can contribute equally to society?

Akula: Poor people don't want charity of the rich. What I am asking for is empathy. All they want is a fighting chance. They want their kids to go to schools the way our children do, to have health care the way our children do, to understand what the position is of the poor so

HEMANT CHAWLA



20 years ago. Yet, now in 2008, we are hearing that we should pass it on to yet another generation to deal with.

So if I could change the world, what would I propose we do? First, we must ensure that the world's conflicts are resolved through serious and inclusive negotiation processes and creative problem-solving. This is the time to resolve the Kashmir dispute once and for all. Second we must ensure a global culture of non-violence. This same country whose freedom struggle gave the world the example of *ahimsa*. So if I could change the world, I would propose that we don't wait any longer before trying to do so.

that the policies then flow in a way that actually gives the poor opportunities. But what has happened is that the wealthy class has become blind and has not been able to understand its constraints.

Q. From your speech it seems you would like Kashmir to be a separate nation. If Kashmir becomes a nation state, hypothetically speaking, how will it survive economically, politically?

Malik: Kashmir had been an independent sovereign country. As far as the survival of independent Kashmir is concerned, we have a vision statement that Kashmir will emerge on the globe as an independent sovereign country. Kashmir issue is a stumbling block in peace and stability in south Asia. Both the Indian and Pakistani people are romantically involved with Kashmir. There is a need to

accommodate both India and Pakistan in Kashmir.

Q. There is so much respect that is paid to our mothers and sisters and we all largely come from close families. Where does all this stuff about not respecting women come from?

Zinta: We live in a beautiful cocoon and don't really know what is going on there. Lots of baby girls are being killed and the school drop out ratio is higher among girls. I have discovered that within the whole modernity and hypocrisy of India where you worship Laxmi and Parvati and all the goddesses, there are women who are suffering. When they become widow, they are abandoned by their families and have to live in Vrindavan.

Full speeches and debate at:

<http://www.indiatodayconclave.com>